How to Write a Critical Book Review

Reading, Evaluating and Judging a Book

A Thesis Guide

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Abstract

A critical book review is a short piece of academic writing with a demanding job: it must tell the reader what a book argues, show how well the argument is supported, and judge whether the book succeeds. It is not a summary, and it is not an opinion piece. A good review balances fair summary with careful evaluation, and every judgement it makes is supported by evidence from the book itself. This guide explains how to write such a review, step by step, for undergraduate and postgraduate students who are asked to review a book for a course, a journal or an examination.

The guide covers reading a book critically, with notes and questions that prepare the reviewer to judge it; identifying the book's thesis and the structure of its argument; evaluating the evidence, the method and the sources on which the argument rests; and structuring the review so that summary and evaluation work together. It explains how to write an introduction that orients the reader, how to keep the balance between describing the book and judging it, and how to write in a tone that is fair, specific and based on evidence. It also covers the differences between reviewing a monograph, an edited volume and a textbook, the common mistakes that weaken reviews, and a final checklist to use before submitting.

A complete worked example is included: a review of a clearly fictional book, invented for this guide, so that students can see the structure and the tone of a review without any confusion with a real publication. No real author, book or publication is described in the example, and no invented citations appear anywhere in this guide. The suggested reading at the end lists only general types of works that students commonly consult. The central message of the guide is simple: a review earns its authority not from strong opinions but from careful reading, precise evidence and honest judgement.

Keywords: book review, critical reading, academic evaluation, thesis and argument, evidence, monograph, edited volume, textbook

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How to use this guide: read Chapters 1 and 2 before you open the book you must review, because they decide how you read. Use Chapters 3 and 4 while you read and take notes. Use Chapters 5 to 8 while you draft the review. Chapter 9 helps when the book is an edited volume or a textbook rather than a single-author monograph. Chapter 10 gives a full worked example to adapt, and Chapter 11 is your final check before submission.

Chapter 1: What a Book Review Is - and What It Is Not

A book review is a short, evaluative account of a book, written for readers who have not read it and want to know whether it is worth their time. In academic life, reviews serve a practical purpose. A researcher deciding which books to read, a librarian deciding which books to buy, a student choosing a source for an essay, and an editor deciding whether a book deserves attention all rely on reviews. A review is therefore a service to a community of readers, and its value lies in its accuracy and its judgement. A reader who trusts a review should be able to decide, after reading it, whether the book is relevant to them and whether its argument is sound.

Students are often asked to write reviews because the task teaches the central skills of academic work: reading carefully, identifying an argument, weighing evidence, and forming a judgement that can be defended. These are the same skills used in essays, theses and examinations. A review is a small, complete exercise in critical thinking, and it is an honest test of whether the student understood the book or merely read its pages. This chapter explains what a review is, what it is not, and what a reader expects from one.

1.1 A review is an evaluation, not a summary

The most common mistake in a student review is to summarise the book chapter by chapter and stop there. A summary tells the reader what the book says. A review tells the reader whether what the book says is convincing, original and useful, and why. Summary is necessary — the reader cannot judge a book they know nothing about — but summary is only the beginning. In a typical review of 1,000 to 1,500 words, about one third should be summary and about two thirds should be evaluation, discussion and judgement. In a longer review, the proportions are similar: the evaluation is the larger part, because it is the part only the reviewer can provide.

Evaluation means asking questions of the book and answering them with evidence. Does the author prove what they claim, or only assert it? Is the evidence strong, or is it thin, selective or outdated? Does the argument hold together, or does it contradict itself? What does the book add to what was already known? Who will find it useful, and who will not? A review that answers these questions gives the reader something a summary never can: a reasoned opinion they can trust, disagree with, or test against the book itself.

1.2 What a review is not

A review is not a book report. A book report, written in school, retells the contents of a book. A review judges them. A review is not a personal essay about whether the reviewer liked the book. Liking a book is not a scholarly judgement, and disliking one is not a criticism, unless the reviewer can say precisely what is good or weak and why. A review is not a platform for the reviewer's own views on the topic. The reviewer may disagree with the author, but the disagreement must be argued from the book's evidence, not asserted from the reviewer's opinions. Finally, a review is not a hostile attack. Even a negative review — one that finds a book weak — should be fair, specific and based on evidence, and should acknowledge what the book does well before explaining where it fails.

Worked Example: Summary versus review

Summary only: 'Chapter 1 introduces the topic, Chapter 2 discusses the history, Chapter 3 presents the findings, and Chapter 4 concludes.' This tells the reader the shape of the book and nothing about its quality. Review: 'The book's argument is strongest in Chapter 3, where the author supports the claim with clear data from four schools. It is weakest in Chapter 2, where the history relies on a single source and ignores the work that challenged it. The book is therefore useful as a study of current practice, but not as a history of the field.' The second version summarises briefly and then judges, with reasons the reader can check.

1.3 Who reads a review, and what do they need?

[ ] I know the difference between summarising a book and reviewing it.

[ ] My review will spend about two thirds of its length on evaluation.

[ ] Every judgement I make will be supported by evidence from the book.

[ ] I have the three readers in mind: general, specialist and potential reader.

Chapter 2: Reading Critically - Notes, Questions, Evidence

A good review is made before a word of it is written, while the reviewer is reading the book. A reviewer who reads passively — turning pages, following the story of the argument, and starting to write only at the end — will produce a review that is mostly summary, because they have not collected the material that evaluation needs. A reviewer who reads critically — with a pen in hand, questions in mind, and notes that record evidence as well as content — will have the material for a review before they sit down to write it. This chapter explains how to read in that way.

2.1 Reading in three passes

Read the book in three passes, not one. The first pass is quick: read the title, the contents page, the introduction and the conclusion, and skim the chapter headings. In twenty minutes you should know what the book claims, how it is organised, and who it is written for. The second pass is the careful reading: read every chapter, take notes, mark passages that matter, and write down questions as they occur to you. This pass takes most of the time, and it is where the review is built. The third pass is short: re-read the introduction and the conclusion, check your notes against them, and ask whether the book delivered what it promised. If the conclusion claims more than the evidence supports, that is an important finding for the review.

2.2 Taking notes that serve the review

Take notes in a form that serves the review, not in the form of a second copy of the book. For each chapter, write down four things: the chapter's main claim in one sentence; the evidence offered for that claim; anything that seemed weak, unclear or unsupported; and any passage worth quoting, with its page number. Keep the notes short. Long notes that copy the book are useless for a review, because they must be summarised again before they can be used. Short notes that record judgements are useful at once, because they are already the raw material of the review.

Keep a separate list of questions as you read. Does the author define the key terms? Does the evidence come from a wide range of sources, or from a narrow one? Are counter-arguments considered, or ignored? Does the argument change between the introduction and the conclusion? These questions, collected while reading, become the skeleton of the review. A question that keeps returning is usually the most important question to answer in the review. A question that you cannot answer from the book is itself a finding: it shows a gap in the book's argument.

2.3 Marking evidence, not just opinions

When you find a passage that supports a judgement you want to make, mark it with its page number and a word about why it matters. 'Strong evidence, page 84' or 'Claim without evidence, page 112' are notes you can use directly when writing. A review that quotes or refers to specific passages is far more convincing than one that makes general claims about the book. 'The author ignores the earlier work on this question' is a weak sentence. 'The author discusses the earlier work only in a

footnote on page 45, and does not answer its main objection' is a strong one, because the reader can check it.

Worked Example: Notes that make a review

For one chapter, a student wrote four lines: Claim: 'Peer feedback improves accuracy more than teacher feedback.' Evidence: a six-week study in four schools, with test scores before and after. Weakness: the study ran only six weeks, and no follow-up test is reported. Worth quoting: the author's definition of structured peer feedback, page 61. From those four lines she later wrote a full paragraph of evaluation, with the evidence, the limit and the quotation all in place. Four lines of notes had done the work of an hour of re-reading.

[ ] I have read the introduction and conclusion, and I can state the book's claim.

[ ] My notes record each chapter's claim, evidence and weaknesses.

[ ] I have a list of questions that arose while I read.

[ ] Key passages are marked with page numbers and a note on why they matter.

[ ] I have left some time between finishing the book and writing the review.

Chapter 3: Identifying the Book's Thesis and Argument

Every academic book has a thesis: a central claim that the whole book is written to support. Finding that thesis is the first task of the reviewer, and it is not always easy. Some authors state their thesis clearly in the introduction. Others leave it to be gathered from the chapters. A few books have no single thesis at all, but a set of related claims, or a survey of a field. The reviewer must work out which kind of book they are reading, state the thesis fairly, and then judge the book against its own aims. A book cannot fairly be criticised for failing to do something it never tried to do.

This chapter explains where to look for the thesis, how to distinguish the thesis from the topic, how to trace the argument through the chapters, and how to state the thesis in the review so that the reader understands what is being judged. The skill is the same one used in reading any academic work: separate what the author claims from what the author shows, and judge the second against the first.

3.1 Thesis, topic and question

A topic is a field: 'feedback in language learning', 'the history of a city', 'the economics of small farms'. A thesis is a claim about that field that can be argued for or against: 'Structured peer feedback improves writing accuracy more than teacher feedback alone.' A research question is the sentence the book answers: 'Does peer feedback improve accuracy?' Many student reviews confuse the topic with the thesis, and describe the book as 'about feedback' without ever saying what the book claims about feedback. That leaves the reader unable to judge the book, because there is nothing to judge.

To find the thesis, read the introduction and the conclusion together. The introduction usually states what the author will argue; the conclusion states what the author

thinks has been shown. If the two agree, the thesis is clear. If they differ — if the conclusion claims more, or less, than the introduction promised — that difference is itself worth noting in the review. Also look at the chapter titles and the first paragraph of each chapter, which usually state what that chapter will contribute to the argument. A book whose chapters each advance the thesis is a well-structured book. A book whose chapters wander from the thesis is one the reviewer should criticise, with examples.

3.2 Tracing the argument through the chapters

Once the thesis is identified, trace how the argument is built. Does each chapter add a step, or does the book repeat the same point in different words? Are the chapters in a logical order, or would a different order have been stronger? Does the author deal with objections, or ignore them? Does the evidence grow stronger as the book proceeds, or does the strongest evidence come early and the later chapters add little? These questions reveal the architecture of the book, and the review should describe that architecture briefly, so that the reader can see how the book works as a whole, not only what it says in each chapter.

Worked Example: Stating the thesis fairly

Weak: 'This book is about peer feedback in schools.' That is the topic, not the thesis, and it gives the reader nothing to judge. Strong: 'This book argues that structured peer feedback improves the writing accuracy of intermediate learners more than teacher feedback alone, and that the improvement lasts beyond the period of the study.' That sentence states a claim that can be tested against the book's evidence, and the review can now ask whether the evidence supports it. Every judgement in the review should refer back to a sentence like this one.

[ ] I can state the book's thesis in one sentence.

[ ] I have checked the thesis against the introduction and the conclusion.

[ ] I can describe how the argument develops from chapter to chapter.

[ ] I know whether the book has a single thesis or a different purpose.

Chapter 4: Evaluating Evidence, Method and Sources

Once the thesis is clear, the reviewer must ask the central question of any review: is the thesis supported? A thesis can be interesting, original and clearly written, and still be unproven, because the evidence is weak, the method is flawed, or the sources are selective. Evaluating the evidence is therefore the heart of a critical review. It is also the part that separates a critical review from a summary. Anyone can report what a book claims. A reviewer must ask whether the claim is earned.

This chapter explains how to evaluate the three things on which an argument rests: the evidence presented, the method used to gather and analyse it, and the sources on which the author relies. The standards are the same across subjects, even though the evidence looks different: numbers in one field, documents in another, interviews in a third. In every field, the reviewer asks whether the evidence is sufficient,

relevant, reliable and fairly presented.

4.1 Is the evidence sufficient and relevant?

Sufficient evidence means enough of it: enough cases, enough examples, enough data to support a general claim. A book that claims a general finding on the basis of one case, one school or one interview has not provided sufficient evidence, however vivid the case is. The reviewer should say so, and say what would have been needed: more cases, a wider sample, a longer study. Relevant evidence means evidence that bears on the claim. A book about peer feedback that offers evidence about general classroom motivation has not supported its specific claim, however interesting the evidence is on its own terms. The review should distinguish evidence that supports the thesis from evidence that merely surrounds it.

4.2 Is the method sound?

The method is the way the evidence was gathered and analysed, and it must fit the question. An experiment is the right method for testing whether one thing causes another; a survey is right for describing what a population thinks or does; a case study is right for exploring a phenomenon in depth in its real setting. The reviewer should ask whether the method chosen was the right one for the book's question, whether it was carried out carefully, and whether its limits are acknowledged. A questionnaire with unclear items, an experiment with no control group, or an interview study with a handful of participants and no account of how they were chosen are all weaknesses the review should name, with the page references where the method is described.

The reviewer need not be an expert in the method to judge it. The book itself should explain the method clearly enough for a careful reader to follow it. If the method is described so briefly or so unclearly that the reader cannot tell what was done, that is itself a criticism: a scholarly book must allow its readers to judge its evidence, and an unexplained method prevents that. If the method is described clearly, the reviewer can ask the plain questions: who took part, how many, how were they chosen, what was measured, and how was it analysed?

4.3 Are the sources reliable and up to date?

A book's sources are its foundation. The reviewer should look at the references and ask whether they are reliable, relevant and reasonably current. Does the author rely on primary sources — original data, documents, interviews — or mainly on other people's summaries? Does the author cite the key works in the field, or ignore them? Is the most important recent work included, or does the book rely on old sources where newer ones exist? A book that ignores a major study that contradicts its thesis has a serious weakness, and the review should name it, because the specialist reader will have noticed it too.

Question to ask	What good looks like	What to criticise

Is the evidence sufficient?	Enough cases or data for the claim	One case used to prove a general claim

Is the evidence relevant?	Evidence that bears on the thesis	Interesting evidence that does not support the claim

Is the method sound?	Method fits the question, clearly described	No control group, unclear procedure

Are sources reliable?	Primary sources, key works cited	Key work ignored, sources outdated

[ ] I have asked whether the evidence is sufficient for the claim.

[ ] I have checked whether contrary evidence is reported or hidden.

[ ] I can describe the method and say whether it fits the question.

[ ] I have looked at the sources and noted any major work that is ignored.

[ ] My criticisms name pages and examples, not just general faults.

Chapter 5: Structure of the Review

A review needs a structure, just as a book does, and the structure should serve the reader. The reader wants to know, in order: what the book is and what it argues; how the argument is built; whether the evidence supports it; and whether the book is worth reading. The standard structure of a review follows that order, and it works for reviews of almost any length. This chapter sets out that structure, explains what belongs in each part, and shows how the parts connect to each other.

The proportions matter. A common structure for a review of about 1,200 words is: an introduction of about 150 words that identifies the book and states its thesis; a summary of about 350 words that describes the argument and the structure; an evaluation of about 500 words that judges the evidence, the method and the contribution; and a conclusion of about 200 words that gives the overall judgement and the recommendation. Longer reviews expand the evaluation, not the summary. The summary should never grow to fill the review, because the reader can get a summary from the book itself. Only the evaluation is the reviewer's own contribution.

5.1 The standard structure

• Introduction: identify the book, state its thesis, and give the reviewer's overall judgement in brief.

• Summary: describe the argument, the structure and the main findings, fairly and briefly.

• Evaluation: judge the evidence, the method, the sources and the contribution, with examples.

• Conclusion: restate the overall judgement, say who should read the book, and recommend it or not.

5.2 Planning before writing

Before writing, plan the review on one page. Write the thesis of the book in one sentence. Write your overall judgement in one sentence: is the book strong, weak, or mixed, and why? List three strengths and three weaknesses, each with a page reference. Decide the order in which you will discuss them, from the most important to the least. Then write the review from that plan, in order, without going back to the book except to check a quotation or a page number. A review written from a plan is focused and balanced. A review written without one wanders, repeats itself, and often ends without a clear judgement.

Worked Example: A one-page plan for a review

Thesis of the book: 'Structured peer feedback improves writing accuracy more than teacher feedback alone.' Overall judgement: 'A strong study with a clear finding, weakened by a short time frame and a narrow sample.' Strengths: clear method, honest reporting of results, useful guidance for teachers. Weaknesses: six-week study only, four schools in one city, no follow-up test. Order: method first, then evidence, then limits, then contribution. From this plan, the reviewer wrote a review of 1,200 words in which every paragraph had a job and the judgement was clear from the first paragraph to the last.

[ ] My plan states the book's thesis and my overall judgement in one sentence each.

[ ] I have three strengths and three weaknesses, each with a page reference.

[ ] The summary is about one third of the review; the evaluation is the larger part.

[ ] Each paragraph has one job, and I can say what it is.

Chapter 6: Writing the Introduction

The introduction of a review has three jobs, and it must do them quickly, usually in one paragraph. It must identify the book: title, author, publisher, year and pages, so that the reader knows exactly which book is being reviewed. It must state the book's thesis, so that the reader knows what is being judged. And it must give the reviewer's overall judgement, so that the reader knows where the review is heading. A reader who has read only the introduction should know what the book argues and whether the reviewer thinks it succeeds.

Many student reviews fail at the first paragraph by spending it on general remarks about the topic — 'Feedback has long been an important issue in education...' — before ever naming the book. That wastes the most valuable space in the review. Start with the book itself. The topic can be introduced in a sentence, as part of stating

the thesis, but the book must come first. The reader opened the review to learn about a book, not about a topic in general.

6.1 Identifying the book

Give the full details of the book at the start of the review, usually in the first sentence or in a heading above it. The details are: the author's name, the full title, the publisher, the year of publication, the number of pages, and the price if that is relevant to the reader. If the book is part of a series, or a new edition of an earlier book, say so. If the book is a translation, say so, and name the translator if that matters. These details are not decoration. They let the reader find the book, and they show that the reviewer has the right book in front of them. In a journal review, the details are usually given in a standard heading; in a course assignment, they belong in the first paragraph.

6.2 Stating the thesis and the judgement

After identifying the book, state its thesis in one or two sentences, in your own words. Then give your overall judgement in one sentence. The judgement should be honest and specific: 'This is a careful and useful study, although its short time frame limits what it can claim,' is a good opening judgement. 'This is an excellent book' is not, because it says nothing specific, and the reader cannot tell what is excellent about it. 'This book is disappointing' is also too vague; the reader needs to know in what way it disappoints, and the introduction should give a hint of that, with the detail to follow in the evaluation.

Worked Example: A strong opening paragraph

Fictional example. 'In The Listening Classroom, a study of peer feedback in secondary schools, the author argues that structured peer feedback improves writing accuracy more than teacher feedback alone, and that the improvement lasts beyond the period of the study. The argument is supported by a clear and honestly reported experiment, and the book offers practical guidance that teachers will value. Its main weakness is its narrow base: four schools, six weeks, and no follow-up. It is therefore a strong and useful book, but one whose findings need testing on a wider scale.' In five sentences, the reader knows the book, its thesis, its strengths, its weakness and the overall judgement.

- [ ] The first paragraph identifies the book fully: author, title, publisher, year, pages.
- [ ] The book's thesis is stated in my own words.
- [ ] My overall judgement appears in the introduction, in one specific sentence.
- [ ] No space is wasted on general remarks about the topic before the book is named.

Chapter 7: Balancing Summary and Evaluation

The hardest skill in writing a review is balance: giving enough summary for the reader to follow the evaluation, without letting summary take over the review. A review that is mostly summary is a book report. A review that is mostly evaluation, with too little summary, is confusing, because the reader does not know what is being judged. The balance is not a matter of counting words. It is a matter of purpose: every piece of summary should exist to support a judgement, and every judgement should be understandable from the summary that precedes it.

The practical rule is simple. Summarise a chapter or an argument only as far as the reader needs to understand your judgement of it. If you are going to praise the method, summarise the method. If you are going to criticise the evidence, summarise the evidence. If a chapter is not going to be judged, summarise it in a sentence or leave it out. The reader does not need a tour of the whole book. They need the parts that matter to the judgement, described clearly enough to follow it.

7.1 Summary that serves evaluation

Good summary in a review is selective and brief. It states the author's claim, the evidence offered, and the conclusion reached, in the reviewer's own words, and it does so in a few sentences per chapter or per section. It does not copy the author's language, and it does not list every detail. A useful habit is to write the summary as if you were explaining the book to a colleague who has not read it, in two minutes, before telling them what you think of it. That is exactly the reader's position, and a summary written for that reader will be the right length and the right level of detail.

7.2 Evaluation that stays close to the book

Evaluation should stay close to the book. A judgement is strong when it points to a specific passage, a specific piece of evidence, or a specific gap, and explains why it matters. A judgement is weak when it floats above the book in general terms: 'The book is well written', 'The argument is unconvincing', 'The author should have done more'. Each of these may be true, but without evidence the reader cannot tell, and the review gives them no reason to agree. Always follow a judgement with its reason and its evidence: 'The argument is unconvincing here, because the only evidence offered is a single case, described on page 96, with no comparison group.'

Stay with the book's own aims when you evaluate it. A book that aims to introduce beginners to a subject should be judged on clarity and accuracy, not on whether it breaks new ground. A book that aims to advance a new theory should be judged on the strength of its argument, not on whether it is easy to read. Judging a book against aims it never had is unfair, and the specialist reader will notice. If a book's aims are unclear, say so: that is itself a criticism, because a scholarly book should make its purpose clear.

Worked Example: Balanced paragraph: summary then judgement

Summary: 'Chapter 4 reports a six-week study in four schools, in which the

peer-feedback group improved by about 13 points, against 8 points for teacher feedback and 2 points for the control group.' Judgement: 'This is the strongest chapter in the book, because the design is clear, the groups are comparable, and the results are reported honestly, including the small gain in the control group. Its limit is the time frame: six weeks is too short to show whether the gain lasts, and the book offers no follow-up data.' The summary gives the reader the facts; the judgement gives them the reviewer's view, with reasons that can be checked against the book.

[ ] About one third of my review is summary; about two thirds is evaluation.

[ ] Every piece of summary supports a judgement that follows it.

[ ] The author's voice and my voice are clearly separated by signposting.

[ ] Each judgement is followed by its reason and its evidence from the book.

[ ] I am judging the book against its own aims, not against aims it never had.

Chapter 8: Tone - Fair, Specific, Evidence-Based

Tone is the attitude a review expresses towards the book and its author, and it matters as much as content. A review with the right tone is trusted even when it is critical. A review with the wrong tone is dismissed even when its points are correct. The right tone for an academic review is fair, specific and based on evidence. Fair means giving credit where it is due and criticising only what deserves criticism. Specific means naming the passage, the page and the problem, rather than dealing in general praise or blame. Evidence-based means that every judgement can be checked against the book.

Tone is not a matter of being polite. A review can be polite and still be devastating, if its criticisms are precise and supported. Nor is tone a matter of being harsh. A harsh review that calls a book 'worthless' or 'a failure' without evidence tells the reader more about the reviewer than about the book. The strongest reviews are calm in tone and firm in judgement. They praise what is good without exaggeration, and they criticise what is weak without insult. That combination is what makes a review authoritative.

8.1 Being fair: credit before criticism

A fair review acknowledges the book's strengths before, or alongside, its weaknesses. This is not politeness. It is accuracy: almost every book has something to praise — a clear method, a useful set of data, a well-written chapter — and a review that ignores that is not a true account of the book. Crediting strengths also makes criticism more credible. A reader who sees that the reviewer noticed what is good will trust the reviewer when they say what is weak. A reviewer who praises nothing looks biased, and a reader will suspect that the criticism says more about the reviewer's attitude than about the book.

8.2 Being specific: name the page, the passage, the problem

Specific criticism is useful criticism. 'The method is weak' helps nobody. 'The method

is weak because the study used only twelve students, with no control group, as described on page 78' helps the reader, the author and the field. Specific praise is equally useful. 'The book is well written' is vague. 'The book explains a difficult idea clearly on page 61, using a classroom example that a teacher could use at once' tells the reader what is good and where to find it. Whenever you write a judgement, ask yourself whether the reader could find the evidence for it in the book. If they could not, the judgement is not specific enough.

Specificity also protects the reviewer. A general attack on a book invites a general defence, and the argument goes nowhere. A specific criticism, tied to a page and a passage, can be answered, corrected or conceded, and the discussion moves forward. That is how academic debate works, and a review is part of that debate. Write as if the author will read your review — because they may — and as if they deserve a review they can learn from, even when they disagree with it.

8.3 Words that help and words that harm

Some words help a review and some harm it. Helpful words are precise and measured: 'convincing', 'well supported', 'limited', 'unclear', 'suggests', 'fails to show'. They describe what the book does, and they leave room for the reader to judge for themselves. Harmful words are vague or absolute: 'brilliant', 'terrible', 'obviously', 'clearly', 'everyone knows'. They assert more than they show, and they make the reviewer sound as if they are performing rather than judging. Avoid sarcasm, jokes at the author's expense, and personal remarks of any kind. A review judges a book, not a person, and a personal remark damages the reviewer's reputation more than the author's.

Worked Example: Fair criticism in practice

Unfair: 'This book is a disappointment and adds nothing to the field.' No evidence, no specifics, no credit for anything. Fair: 'The book's central finding is clearly presented and honestly reported, and teachers will find Chapter 5 useful. However, the finding rests on a six-week study in four schools, and the book offers no follow-up evidence that the improvement lasts. Until a longer study is done, the book's claim should be treated as promising rather than proven.' The second version praises what is good, names the weakness precisely, and gives the reader a judgement they can use.

- [ ] I have credited the book's strengths before or alongside its weaknesses.
- [ ] Every criticism names a page, a passage or a specific problem.
- [ ] My language is measured and precise, not vague or absolute.
- [ ] There is no sarcasm, no joke at the author's expense, and no personal remark.
- [ ] I have written as if the author will read the review.

Chapter 9: Reviewing Different Kinds of Books

Not all books are the same, and a review must adjust to the kind of book it is judging. A single-author monograph, an edited volume with many contributors, and a textbook for students have different purposes, different structures and different standards. A reviewer who applies the standards of one kind to another will produce an unfair review. This chapter explains the three most common kinds of academic book, what each one aims to do, and how the review should judge it.

The first step is always to identify the kind of book you are reviewing. The title page, the introduction and the contents page usually make it clear. If the book has one author and one sustained argument, it is a monograph. If it has an editor and chapters by different authors, it is an edited volume. If it is written to teach a subject to students, with exercises, summaries and a clear progression, it is a textbook. Each kind is judged below, in turn.

9.1 The monograph: one author, one argument

A monograph is the most common kind of book reviewed in academic journals. One author presents one sustained argument, supported by original research, over the whole book. The review should judge it as a whole: is the thesis clear, is the argument well built, is the evidence sufficient, and does the book make a contribution to the field? The review should also judge the parts: are the chapters in a logical order, does each one advance the argument, and are the strongest chapters given the space they deserve?

9.2 The edited volume: many authors, one theme

An edited volume collects chapters by different authors, chosen and introduced by an editor, usually around a single theme. The review must judge two things: the quality of the individual chapters, and the coherence of the whole. A volume with strong chapters that do not connect to each other is a weak volume, however good the chapters are alone. A volume with a clear introduction that explains how the chapters fit together, and a conclusion that draws them together, is a strong one, even if some chapters are weaker than others.

9.3 The textbook: teaching a subject well

A textbook is written to teach, not to advance new research, and it must be judged by teaching standards. Is the content accurate and up to date? Is it organised in a logical order, from simple to complex? Is the language clear for the students who will use it? Are there worked examples, exercises, summaries and questions that help a student learn? Are the diagrams, tables and illustrations clear and correct? A textbook that is accurate but unreadable has failed, just as a textbook that is readable but inaccurate has failed.

Kind of book	Main purpose	Judge it mainly on

Monograph	Advance one argument	Originality, evidence, coherence

Edited volume	Collect work on a theme	Quality of chapters, coherence of the whole

Textbook	Teach a subject	Accuracy, clarity, organisation, exercises

[ ] I have identified which kind of book I am reviewing.

[ ] For a monograph, I can say what is new and what it contributes.

[ ] For an edited volume, I have judged the whole, not only the best chapter.

[ ] For a textbook, I have judged clarity, accuracy and teaching features.

[ ] My judgement fits the book's own purpose, not a different kind of book.

Chapter 10: Worked Example - A Review of a Fictional Book

This chapter presents a complete review of a clearly fictional book. The book, its author, its publisher, its study and its findings are all invented for this guide, to show the structure and the tone of a review. No real author, book, school or study is described, and no real publication should be confused with the one below. The review is about 900 words long, which is a typical length for a course assignment. Read it as a model: notice where summary ends and evaluation begins, how each judgement is supported by evidence from the book, and how the review ends with a clear recommendation.

10.1 The fictional book

The fictional book is 'The Listening Classroom: Peer Feedback and Writing Accuracy in Secondary Schools', by a fictional author, published by a fictional university press. It reports a six-week study in four fictional secondary schools, with 120 intermediate learners divided into three groups: peer feedback, teacher feedback, and a control group. The book argues that structured peer feedback improves writing accuracy more than teacher feedback alone, and that the improvement lasts. The review below judges that claim, the evidence for it, and the book's usefulness for teachers and researchers.

Worked Example: The worked review (fictional book, fictional author)

The Listening Classroom: Peer Feedback and Writing Accuracy in Secondary Schools. By A. Rahman (fictional author). Fictional University Press, 2026. 184 pages. In this short and clearly written book, the author argues that structured peer feedback improves the writing accuracy of intermediate learners more than teacher feedback alone, and that the improvement lasts beyond the period of the study. The argument is supported by a

careful experiment, honestly reported, and the book offers practical guidance that teachers will value. Its main weakness is its narrow base, and its findings need testing on a wider scale before they can be treated as settled. The book is organised in six chapters. The first states the problem: students write every week, yet their accuracy improves slowly. The second reviews earlier work on feedback and identifies a gap: earlier studies showed that learners value feedback, but none had measured whether peer feedback improved accuracy in a public-school classroom. The third chapter describes the method: three groups, six weeks, four schools, with a writing test before and after the study. The fourth chapter presents the results, with clear tables and graphs. The fifth chapter discusses what the results mean. The sixth chapter draws out the implications for teaching and for future research. The method is the book's greatest strength. The groups were matched on pre-test scores, the same material was taught in all three groups, and the marking was checked by a second marker. The results are reported honestly, including the small gain in the control group, which suggests that the author has not selected only the results that help the argument. The peer-feedback group improved by about 13 points, against 8 points for teacher feedback and 2 points for the control group, and the difference is presented clearly in a single bar chart that a reader can understand at a glance. The book is also useful in a practical sense. Chapter 5 gives a clear structure for peer-feedback sessions, with examples of the prompts teachers can use, and the guidance is written in plain language that a working teacher can follow without further training. The book's weaknesses are real, and the author is honest about most of them. The study ran for only six weeks, in four schools in one city, and no follow-up test is reported, so the claim that the improvement lasts is not supported by the book's own data. The sample is also limited to intermediate learners, and the book says little about whether the method would work for beginners or for advanced learners. A further weakness is the literature review, which relies heavily on work from one country and does not discuss the studies that found smaller effects for peer feedback. These limits do not destroy the book's value, but they do limit what it can claim. The Listening Classroom is a strong and useful book within its limits. Teachers who want a practical, evidence-based approach to peer feedback will find it clear and encouraging. Researchers will find a well-designed study that needs to be repeated on a larger scale, over a longer period, and in more varied settings. The book does not settle the question of peer feedback, but it advances it, and it does so honestly. It is recommended for teachers, for students of language teaching, and for anyone planning research on feedback in the classroom.

10.2 What the worked review does well

Notice four things about the worked review. First, the introduction identifies the book, states its thesis, and gives the overall judgement in the first paragraph, so that the reader knows where the review is heading. Second, the summary is brief — one paragraph describing the structure and the study — and it exists to support the evaluation that follows. Third, every judgement is supported by evidence from the book: the method is praised because the groups were matched and the marking was checked; the claim about lasting improvement is questioned because no follow-up

test is reported. Fourth, the conclusion gives a clear recommendation, saying who should read the book and what they will gain from it, and it is honest about the limits of the findings.

10.3 Adapting the example to your own review

To adapt this example, keep the structure and replace the content. Write your own introduction, identifying your book and stating its thesis and your overall judgement. Write a brief summary of your book's structure and argument, in your own words. Write your evaluation from your notes, working through the strengths and the weaknesses in order of importance, each with its page reference and its evidence. End with a conclusion that restates your judgement and recommends the book, or not, for a named audience. Do not copy sentences from the example, and do not copy its judgements: they belong to a fictional book, and they will not fit a real one. What you should copy is the shape — introduction, brief summary, evidence-based evaluation, clear recommendation — because that shape works for almost any academic book.

[ ] My review follows the worked example's shape, not its sentences.

[ ] My introduction identifies the book, states its thesis and gives my judgement.

[ ] My summary is brief and supports the evaluation that follows.

[ ] Every judgement in my evaluation has evidence and a page reference.

[ ] My conclusion recommends the book, or not, for a named audience.

Chapter 11: Common Mistakes and a Checklist

The mistakes in this chapter appear in student reviews again and again, in every subject. They are not mistakes of intelligence. They are mistakes of preparation and of balance, and every one of them is avoidable. Read this chapter before you write your review, and read it again when the draft is finished, as a final check. A review that avoids these mistakes will already be better than most.

11.1 The ten most common mistakes

- Summarising the book chapter by chapter and never evaluating it.
- Stating opinions without evidence: 'The book is excellent' or 'The argument fails', with no reason given.
- Confusing the topic with the thesis, and never saying what the book claims.
- Judging the book against aims it never had, such as criticising a textbook for lacking original research.
- Quoting at length instead of paraphrasing, so that the review is mostly the author's words.
- Quoting out of context, or misrepresenting what the author actually says.
- Ignoring the book's weaknesses, or ignoring its strengths, instead of judging both fairly.
- Using vague or absolute language: 'brilliant', 'terrible', 'obviously', 'clearly'.

• Writing a personal essay about whether the reviewer liked the book, instead of a scholarly judgement.

• Ending without a clear overall judgement or recommendation, so the reader does not know whether to read the book.

11.2 Mistakes of fairness

Some mistakes are not about structure but about fairness. The first is reviewing a book the reviewer has not finished. A review based on the introduction and a skim of the chapters is not a review, and the gaps will show: the reviewer will miss the argument's development, the later evidence, and the conclusion. Always finish the book, and always read the conclusion, before you write. The second is reviewing a book in a field the reviewer knows nothing about, without doing the background reading to judge it. If you do not know the key works in the field, you cannot judge whether the book's claims are new or its sources are adequate. Do the reading, or say honestly where your knowledge ends.

11.3 The final checklist

Work through this checklist with your draft and your notes in front of you. Tick each item only when you have checked it on the page, not from memory. If an item is not ticked, fix it now, while there is still time to revise.

[ ] I have read the whole book, including the conclusion.

[ ] The book's thesis is stated in my own words in the introduction.

[ ] About one third of the review is summary; about two thirds is evaluation.

[ ] Every judgement has evidence from the book and a page reference.

[ ] Strengths and weaknesses are both judged, fairly and in proportion.

[ ] The tone is fair, specific and evidence-based, with no personal remarks.

[ ] Quotations are brief, accurate and given with page numbers.

[ ] The conclusion gives a clear overall judgement and a recommendation.

[ ] The review is the required length, and it has been proofread.

[ ] The book's details (author, title, publisher, year, pages) are correct.

Chapter 12: Conclusion

A critical book review is a small piece of writing with a large purpose. It tells readers what a book argues, whether the argument is supported, and whether the book is worth their time. It does this not through strong opinions but through careful reading, precise evidence and honest judgement. The skills it teaches — identifying a thesis, weighing evidence, judging a method, forming a judgement that can be defended — are the skills of all academic work, and they improve with every review you write.

If you take one idea from this guide, let it be this: read the book as if you will have to defend your judgement of it, because in a sense you will. Every claim in your review should be traceable to a page, a passage or a piece of evidence in the book. If you can do that, your review will be trusted, even by readers who disagree with you, and

even by the author of the book. Write the review from your notes, keep summary and evaluation in balance, be fair and specific, and end with a clear recommendation. Then submit it with confidence, and start the next book with the knowledge that you are now a better reader than you were before.

Suggested Reading

The following are general, well-known types of works that students commonly consult when learning to write academic reviews. Check your university library for the latest editions, and follow your department's guidance on referencing style and on review assignments.

- Standard guides to academic writing: widely used guides explain how to structure an argument, evaluate evidence and write clearly, with examples from many subjects.
- Guides to critical reading and critical thinking: general works on reading actively, asking questions of a text, and forming reasoned judgements are useful preparation for reviewing any book.
- Guides to writing book reviews: standard works on the review as a form explain its structure, its tone and its conventions, with examples of reviews in different subjects.
- The official manual of your referencing style: the authoritative source for citation and formatting rules — consult the edition your department requires.
- Your university's guidance on review assignments, and your supervisor's or tutor's recommended reading for your subject: the most relevant sources, because they are chosen for your specific course and field.